WORLD WAR II

IWO JIMA



Date February 19–March 26, 1945
Forces Americans: Over 800 ships, 74,000 Marines; Japanese: 23,000 soldiers
Losses Americans: 1 escort carrier, 1 tank landing craft, 1 infantry landing craft
Location Iwo Jima, Ogasawara Islands

Lying halfway between the Marianas and the Japanese mainland, the small volcanic island of Iwo Jima was of limited military value. But the Americans decided to take the island as a stepping stone across the Pacific, and the Japanese defended it to the death.

The Iwo Jima landings were an amphibious operation on an awesome scale. Almost 500 ships were dedicated to transporting and landing more than 70,000 men of the 3rd, 4th, and 5th Marine Divisions. Hundreds of other ships were deployed in support, including battleships, cruisers, and escort carriers. The US Navy was not expecting interference from the Imperial Japanese Navy, which was no longer a viable fighting force, and Iwo Jima was far distant from Japanese air bases. The function of the US armada was to bombard the island and land Marines. The naval bombardment of Iwo Jima began three days before the landings—a much shorter softening-up than the Marines would have liked. Battleships and cruisers fired a total of 22,000 shells into the island. The effect of this onslaught and the accompanying aerial bombardment was slight. Under Lieutenant General Tadamichi Kuribayashi, the 22,000 soldiers on the island had created a network of strongpoints and bunkers linked by tunnels deep inside the cave-riddled volcanic rock. When the first wave of Marines came ashore at 8:59 a.m. on the morning of February 19, the Japanese were ready to receive them.

MARINE ASSAULT

The initial landing was not contested. The Japanese only opened fire when a log-jam of Marines and equipment had built up on the beaches, trapped by the volcanic terrain. Sailors bringing landing craft into shore had to contend not only with enemy fire but also with waves that dashed boats onto the beach. Close support for the Marines from naval guns and carrier aircraft was inhibited by worsening weather. On February 21 the attack carrier *Saratoga* and escort carrier *Bismarck Sea* were hit by attacks from Japanese kamikaze aircraft. *Saratoga* limped away for repairs after fires and explosions caused over 300 casualties on board; *Bismarck Sea* was blown apart and sank with the loss of 318 men.

The outcome of the battle was never in doubt, but the human cost was appalling. By the time the island was finally secured the Marines had suffered over 23,000 casualties and the US Navy around 2,000. Almost all the Japanese soldiers on the island died.

WITNESS TO WAR

US SEAMAN WILLIAM P. CAMPBELL

CREWMAN ON AMPHIBIOUS VEHICLE DURING LANDINGS AT IWO JIMA

BATTLE OF IWO JIMA

"We made it in all right carrying in troops off the ship. ***My trouble started when I went back*** *and picked up a load of medical supplies a little after dark.* ***I went onto the beach and couldn't get off****. They'd shoot flares and it would* ***light the whole island up, just like it was daylight*** *… I was at the back of the boat when a shell or mortar hit the front of the boat.* ***It blew the bow door off it.*** *We got off that thing and dug a foxhole …"*



The beaches of Iwo Jima
US Marines make their way up the volcanic beaches on Iwo Jima. The Japanese waited until the beaches were full of men and equipment before opening fire.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

AMPHIBIOUS WARFARE

The Americans deployed an impressive range of amphibious vehicles during the Pacific War. The most basic was the LCVP (Landing Craft Vehicle Personnel) or Higgins Boat. Men climbed down netting from transports into these shallow-draft wooden boats to be ferried ashore. More than 23,000 LCVPs were built in World War II, along with 11,000 LCMs (Landing Craft Mechanized) designed to carry tanks and other vehicles. The larger LCI (Landing Craft Infantry) was an oceangoing vessel capable of carrying 200 soldiers. Alongside these landing craft a number of inventive types of amphibious vehicle were used. These included the DUKW, an amphibious wheeled truck, and various forms of LVT (Landing Vehicle Tracked). LVTs were basically designed to carry men ashore, but they developed in the course of the war into armored vehicles, some equipped with turret guns so that they could function as amphibious tanks.



DUKW amphibious truck
This US Navy six-wheel drive truck carried 25 soldiers and could maintain a speed of 5 knots in the water.